

C31 — Behavioral Interviews: Stories That Hold Up

1. What interviewers test

"Tell me about yourself." "Why product management?" "Tell me about a time you disagreed with your manager." "Tell me about a decision you got wrong." "Describe a time you protected users against a business request." The behavioral round is often the gate that decides an offer after strong product and analytical rounds, because it tests what the others cannot: how you actually behave with people, under pressure, with incomplete information and real consequences. Interviewers cannot watch you work, so they ask for evidence from your past and judge it for what it reveals. This chapter is a method for building stories from your own work that are specific, honest, well chosen and able to survive probing.

Where it shows up. Inferred from the round structures candidates commonly report: behavioral and "leadership" rounds at Google, Meta, Microsoft, Amazon, Apple, Netflix, Stripe and others, often one or more dedicated rounds plus behavioral openers in every other round, and a hiring-committee or hiring-manager conversation [unverified: candidate-reported]. Several companies publish the attributes or values they assess (C31.1). For a candidate with about two years of experience, the round tests judgment and growth more than scale: what you owned, how you thought, what you did when it was hard, and what you learned.

What is scored. The **signal** your answer gives. A **signal** is what an interviewer infers about your judgment, skills, values or growth from an answer. A story with no specifics gives no signal; a story where you made a real decision, took a real action and learned something real gives a lot. Interviewers listen for ownership (you, not only the team), judgment (why this option), results with evidence, honesty about mistakes, concern for users and colleagues, and the ability to reflect and change.

Six observable behaviors:

1. You introduce yourself in about two minutes with a clear arc and three proof points.
2. You give honest, specific reasons for product management and for the company and role.
3. You tell stories with a clear context, decision, action, result and learning, in two to three minutes.
4. You separate what you did from what the team did, and you give credit.
5. You answer probes three levels deep with concrete detail, and you do not inflate.
6. You handle failure, weakness, hypotheticals and values scenarios with judgment and without evasion.

The failure this prevents. Six patterns end behavioral answers: a rambling background with no arc, a generic motive ("I love solving problems"), a story told entirely as "we," a result with no number, a "weakness" that is a disguised strength, and a values question answered with what you think the interviewer wants to hear.

2. The concept from first principles

C31.1 What the round tests; attribute maps

Interviewers use a short list of attributes, sometimes published, to organize their notes (FW-C31-01). Where a company publishes its list, preparing against it is sensible; where it does not, any claim about what it assesses is inference.

Company	What is published or reported	Label
Amazon	Sixteen Leadership Principles on its careers site, including Customer Obsession, Ownership, Invent and Simplify, Are Right A Lot, Bias for Action, Frugality, Earn Trust, Dive Deep, Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit, and Deliver Results; the list grew from fourteen to sixteen in 2021	Public [V: Amazon's Leadership Principles page, amazon.jobs]
Google	Careers pages describe attributes assessed in hiring, commonly given as general cognitive ability, role-related knowledge, leadership and an attribute called "Googleness", which Google has said should not be confused with culture fit	Public [V: summaries citing Google's how-we-hire page; Work Rules; The Information on the Googleness clarification]
Meta	Published company values emphasize moving fast, focusing on long-term impact and direct communication	Public [V: Meta's careers culture page]
Microsoft	Culture materials emphasize a growth mindset, customer focus and collaboration	Public [V: Microsoft careers culture page]
Netflix	A published culture memo (June 2024) with four principles, candor as a value, context not control and the keeper test	Public [V: Netflix culture memo]
Stripe	Published operating principles (for example, users first, and move with urgency and focus)	Public [V: Stripe careers pages, principles list; also quoted by The Pragmatic Engineer]
Apple	No published rubric; candidates commonly report an emphasis on craft, collaboration, discretion and attention to detail	Inferred [unverified: candidate-reported]

How to use a map. *Stories first, labels second.* Build stories from your real work (C31.5), then see which attributes each shows. Do not invent stories to fit a list, and do not recite principle names in your answers. A story about disagreeing with a manager and then committing shows an Amazon-style attribute without your saying so; naming the principle adds nothing and can sound rehearsed. Use the map to check coverage and to choose which stories to lead with in a given loop.

What nearly every company tests, whatever it is called. Ownership (you took responsibility), judgment (you chose among real options with reasons), working with others (conflict, influence, feedback), customer or user focus, learning from failure, and integrity under pressure.

C31.2 Your two-minute introduction

"Tell me about yourself" and "walk me through your background" are the most predictable questions and the most often wasted. A good answer is about two minutes (roughly 260 to 300 words at a natural pace), has an arc, and plants three proof points that the interviewer can probe later (FW-C31-02).

Structure. *Present:* what you do now, in one or two sentences with scope ("I'm a product analyst on a team of six responsible for onboarding for a budgeting app used by about 400,000 people"). *Past:* two or three steps that explain how you got here, each with a reason and a proof point (a result, a decision you owned). *Future:* why this role and why now, tied to what you have shown. End by handing over: "I'm happy to go deeper on any of those."

Choose proof points that are specific, recent and relevant to the role, and that you can talk about for five minutes. Each should hint at a story in your bank. Leave out: your whole résumé in order, school detail beyond a clause, apologies ("I only have two years").

Variants. "Walk me through your résumé" invites the same arc with the order of your résumé; "tell me about a project you're proud of" is a story question (C31.4). Worked example 1 rewrites a weak introduction into a strong one.

C31.3 Why product management, and why this company and role

Why product management. Interviewers have heard "I like solving problems" and "I'm a bridge between teams" thousands of times, and they give no signal. A good answer points to evidence: moments in your work when you were drawn to the problem of what to build and why; what you did about it; and what you learned about the work (the unglamorous parts included: prioritizing, saying no, living with ambiguity). Test it: could someone who does not want to be a PM say the same words? If so, add specifics.

Why this company and role. Name one or two concrete reasons that connect something real about the company (a product you use and have views on, a published principle you act on, a problem space) to something real about you (a past decision, a skill). Avoid flattery ("you're the best") and facts everyone knows. Show you did the work: you have read the product's recent changes, tried it, and can say what you would examine first in the role. Honest reasons about career growth are fine if they are paired with what you offer.

"What is your favorite product of ours?" This tests taste and candor. Choose a real favorite you actually use, say who it is for and what job it does, name two or three specific design decisions you admire and why they serve users, and then give one honest critique with how you would improve it (C11's teardown method: observation, inference, opinion). Do not choose a product to flatter; do not criticize it as if you knew internal constraints. For an Apple-type question, "what is a product detail you admire and what did it cost to get right?" is the craft-and-tradeoff version (IQ-C31-05).

When not to over-prepare the script. A memorized motive reads as one. Prepare the evidence and the structure; let the words vary.

C31.4 Story anatomy: context, decision, action, result, learning

A well-formed story answers the question in about two to three minutes (FW-C31-03). A common structure, widely recommended in interview preparation, is STAR (situation, task, action, result) Public [V: Widely recommended in interview preparation (Glassdoor guide; consulting and Amazon-focused prep sites); some sites claim it originated at Amazon, which these sources do not establish and the book does not claim]. It is a good skeleton and has a weakness: it can bury the decision and the learning. A stronger version for PM roles:

1. **Context (about 20% of the time).** The situation, the stakes and the constraint, in two or three sentences: who was affected, what was at risk, what made it hard. Include one number if you can.
2. **Decision (20%).** The choice that was yours: the options you saw and why you chose one. This is the center of a PM story, and the part most candidates skip.
3. **Action (30%).** What you did, step by step, in the first person: whom you talked to, what you built or analyzed, how you persuaded or unblocked. Credit the others where due, and be clear on your part.
4. **Result (20%).** What happened, with evidence: a number with its baseline, or an honest "I don't have the final number; here is what I do know." Include what did not work.
5. **Learning (10%).** What you would do differently, and what has changed in how you work since. Concrete and behavioral, not a platitude.

On a 150-second answer those shares are about 30, 30, 45, 30 and 15 seconds.

"I" and "we." Interviewers hire you, not your team. Use "we" for team outcomes and shared decisions, and "I" for your decisions and actions; if you use only "we," they cannot tell what you did, and if you use only "I," you sound like you did not work with anyone. A useful test: for each "we," could you say what you personally did?

Specifics. Numbers, names (of roles, not private people), dates, tools and quotes make a story credible: "the signup form had 12 fields and 41% of people stopped before the end," not "the signup flow was bad." Every figure must be true; invented detail is the quickest way to fail a probe (C31.7).

Honesty about confidentiality. Describe the situation without revealing confidential details (use ranges, relative changes, generic names for customers). If you cannot share a number, say so and give a relative one.

C31.5 Building a story bank from real work

A **story bank** is a prepared set of real experiences, each with notes, mapped to the themes interviewers ask about, from which you choose stories for each question. The point is coverage with a manageable number of stories, each rehearsed and fact-checked (FW-C31-04).

Steps.

1. *Inventory.* List 12 to 15 episodes from the last two years (more if you have them): projects, launches, disagreements, mistakes, moments of ambiguity, times you helped someone, times you changed your mind. Include work beyond your job title: internships, campus and community projects, hackathons, volunteering, side projects. For someone with about two years of experience, the best stories often come from the first project you owned, a launch that went wrong, or a disagreement you handled.
2. *Select.* Keep episodes where (a) you made a real decision; (b) the stakes were clear; (c) you can state an outcome with evidence; (d) you learned something; (e) you can tell it truthfully in two to three minutes and for ten more under probing.
3. *Map to themes.* Conflict, failure, influence without authority, ambiguity, customer focus, a data-driven decision, prioritization, leading others, and a values moment (C31.6). Most strong stories fit two or three themes with different emphasis. Aim to cover each theme with at least one story and the most common (conflict, failure, influence) with two, so that you never repeat a story within a loop.
4. *Write notes, not scripts.* For each story: one line each for context, decision, action, result and learning; the numbers; the names of roles; two likely probes and their answers; and what to leave out. Scripts sound memorized.
5. *Check the facts.* Verify numbers and dates against your records; remember who did what; confirm what you can say publicly.
6. *Rehearse aloud* and time each at two to three minutes (C31.11).

Worked example 4 builds a bank for a candidate with two years of experience and shows the coverage matrix.

C31.6 Story types

Eight themes cover most behavioral questions. For each, what the interviewer is looking for and the common trap:

Theme	Typical prompt	Looking for	Trap
Conflict	"A time you disagreed with a colleague"	Respect, listening, a real resolution, what you learned about the other person's view	A story where you were simply right; a villain
Failure	"A decision you got wrong"	Ownership, real stakes, a clear lesson with changed behavior	A failure that is a disguised success; blame
Influence without authority	"A time you got people to act without being their manager"	Understanding incentives, evidence, building allies	"I just explained it and they agreed"
Ambiguity	"A time you had unclear goals or little information"	Structuring, assumptions, cheap tests, iteration	Waiting for clarity; no method
Customer or user focus	"A time you went deep on a user problem"	Direct contact with users, insight, a change driven by it	Customer as an abstraction; no user contact

Theme	Typical prompt	Looking for	Trap
Data-driven decision	"A decision you made with data"	Right question, sound analysis, limits of the data, a decision	A dashboard read-out; no decision
Prioritization	"A time you had to say no or cut scope"	Criteria, tradeoffs, communication, impact	Everything was important; no cost named
Leading others	"A time you led a team or a project"	Clarity, delegation, development of others, accountability	Doing everything yourself; credit-taking

A ninth category, *values and judgment*, is treated in C31.10. Many questions combine themes ("a time you influenced a decision using data when you disagreed"), so choose a story that can carry the combination.

C31.7 Handling follow-up probes three levels deep

Interviewers probe to test whether the story is real and whether you understand it (FW-C31-05). Expect questions at three levels:

- *Level 1, the detail*: "What exactly did you do?" "Who was involved?" "How long did it take?"
- *Level 2, the reasoning*: "Why that option and not another?" "What data did you use?" "What did the other person say?" "How did you know it worked?"
- *Level 3, the counterfactual and the limits*: "What would you do differently?" "What if the numbers had been the other way?" "What did you not know at the time?" "Was the result due to your decision or something else?"

How to prepare. For each story, write the answers to two probes at each level. Know your numbers, the options you rejected, and one thing that went wrong.

Counterexample. Asked for a time they influenced a decision, a candidate says they convinced a director with data and that conversion rose 15%. The interviewer asks what the baseline was and what the director first said. The candidate cannot recall either and changes the number twice. The story may have been true; the probes showed that the candidate did not know it well enough to tell it. A better answer: prepare the baseline and the objection beforehand, and when unsure say "I don't recall exactly; it was roughly a quarter" and move on.

How to answer. Pause, then answer the question asked, concretely, in the first person. If you do not remember, say so ("I don't recall the exact figure; it was roughly a quarter of users") and give what you do know. Never invent to fill a gap: a made-up number is discovered by the next probe. If a probe exposes a flaw in your decision, acknowledge it and say what you now think; that is signal of judgment and growth, not failure. Do not become defensive. The probes are the real interview: the first two minutes get you the question, the next ten decide the evaluation **Inferred**.

C31.8 Failure and weakness answers

Failure. The best failure stories have a real cost (money, time, trust, a missed launch), a decision that was yours, an honest account of why you made it, and a learning that changed your behavior, with evidence that it did (FW-C31-06). Avoid failures that are not failures ("I worked too hard"), failures that were someone else's fault, and failures so catastrophic that they raise doubts about your judgment. A good choice for an early-career candidate is a mistake in an analysis, a launch you rushed, or a stakeholder you failed to bring along, told with its cost and the habit you changed.

Structure. Context and stakes; what you decided and why it seemed right then; what went wrong and how you found out; what you did to limit the damage and repair it; what you learned; and the specific thing you do differently now, with an example of the new habit in action.

Weakness. "What is your biggest weakness?" asks for self-awareness. Choose a real weakness that does not disqualify you for this role, say how it shows up with an example, what you are doing about it, and what progress you can show. "I take on too much" and "I'm a perfectionist" are rehearsed and signal evasion. A real, specific one ("I tend to start with analysis when a quick user conversation would settle it faster; I now set a rule to talk to three users before building a model") signals judgment.

C31.9 Situational (hypothetical) questions

"What would you do if..." questions ask for your reasoning in a scenario (FW-C31-07). Unlike behavioral questions, there is no past to draw on, so the interviewer assesses your process and values. A structure: *clarify* the facts you would want (two or three questions); *state the principle or priority* that guides you (users, honesty, the goal); *lay out the options* and their tradeoffs; *say what you would do first*, with reasons; and *say how you would check* whether it worked and what would change your mind. If you have faced something similar, say so and give a short example ("I faced something like this once; here is what I did and what I would do now"): real experience is stronger than theory.

Pitfalls. Answering with a single rule ("I'd escalate"), refusing the premise, or giving a long list of possible actions without choosing. Choose and justify.

C31.10 Values and judgment scenarios: ethics, safety, privacy, pressure to hit a number

These questions test integrity under pressure: "Your manager wants a growth tactic you think is manipulative," "Describe a time you protected users' privacy against a business request," "You learn of a defect that could hurt users the day before launch." They are about what you will do when it costs you something. FW-C31-08 gives a frame.

1. **Facts.** What do you actually know, and what are you assuming? Check before acting.
2. **Stakeholders and harms.** Who could be hurt (users, bystanders, the company), how badly, and how reversibly?
3. **The pressure.** What is driving the request (a target, a deadline), and is the goal legitimate by another route?

4. **Options.** Not only "comply" or "refuse": a safer version, a delay with a plan, a test that measures the real effect, an escalation.
5. **Principle and policy.** What does the law, the company policy or the product's stated principles say? (C10.10 on dark patterns, C25 on governance.)
6. **Action and escalation.** What you would do, whom you would involve, in what order, and how you would communicate it honestly.
7. **The cost you accept.** Say what it might cost you (a missed target, a hard conversation) and why you accept it.

What interviewers want. Not a speech about integrity, but a decision with a cost, a route to the legitimate goal, and respect for the people involved. CS-C31-02 shows a real company decision with a large, known cost.

C31.11 Delivery: length, tone, signposting

- **Length.** Two to three minutes per story; ninety seconds to two minutes for the introduction. Longer answers lose the interviewer; much shorter ones lack detail. Stop when you have made your point and invite probing.
- **Signposting.** Tell the listener where you are: "The situation was..., the decision I had to make was..., what I did was..., the result was..., and what I learned was..." Signposts help the interviewer take notes, which is what they will be judged on.
- **Tone.** Calm, direct, conversational; confident about what you did and open about what you did not know. Avoid jargon the interviewer may not share, avoid self-congratulation and avoid self-deprecation.
- **Pace and pause.** A short pause before answering is fine and shows thought. Speak at a natural pace; nerves speed people up.
- **Video and remote.** Look at the camera for key points, keep a glass of water, and keep a short list of your story headlines out of view of the screen share.
- **Not memorized.** Rehearse until you know the structure and the facts, not the sentences.
- **Listen for the question.** Answer what was asked; if you offer a story for a different theme, say so briefly.

C31.12 Worked stories at three bands

Section 5 gives five worked examples, built as stories with notes and probes (all **Illustrative** composites with invented details), and section 6 shows one prompt answered at three bands (Baseline, Strong, Standout). Section 11 gives twelve questions with model answers, probes and answers to them.

3. Frameworks

Eight frameworks, set out below. The problem-definition template (C02.7), the decision memo (FW-C02-06), the pre-mortem (FW-C02-05), the teardown method (C11) and the scope-negotiation script (FW-C15-07) are reused, not repeated.

FW-C31-01 · The attribute map · Original

- **Inputs:** a target company and what it publishes or what candidates report.
- **Outputs:** a short list of attributes labeled **Public** or **Inferred**, each mapped to one or more stories from your bank, with coverage gaps.
- **Assumptions:** the list is checked against the current source [as of 2026-10].
- **Tradeoffs:** a map guides coverage and tempts you to recite labels.
- **Failure modes:** inventing stories to fit; reciting principle names; treating inference as published fact.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 4 and C31.1.

Attribute	Published or inferred	Story that shows it	Gap
-----------	-----------------------	---------------------	-----

FW-C31-02 · The two-minute introduction · Original

- **Inputs:** your last two to three roles and one target role.
- **Outputs:** a 260 to 300 word introduction with present (scope), past (two or three steps with reasons), three proof points that hint at stories, and a future tied to the role.
- **Assumptions:** you can speak about each proof point for five minutes.
- **Tradeoffs:** a tight arc omits much of your history.
- **Failure modes:** reciting the résumé; no proof points; generic motive.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 1.

Steps: **Present with scope** → **Past in two or three steps, each with a reason and a proof point** → **Future tied to this role** → **Hand over**.

FW-C31-03 · Story anatomy: context, decision, action, result, learning · Original

- **Inputs:** an episode from your work.
- **Outputs:** a story in five parts with time shares (20, 20, 30, 20 and 10 percent of two to three minutes), numbers with baselines, a clear "I" and "we", and a behavioral learning.
- **Assumptions:** you made a real decision and can state an outcome.
- **Tradeoffs:** structure shows judgment and can sound mechanical if scripted.
- **Failure modes:** no decision; all "we"; no numbers; a generic lesson.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 2.

Part	What it contains	Time
Context	Stakes, constraint, one number	20%
Decision	Options and why this one	20%
Action	What you did, in order, with credit	30%
Result	Evidence, baseline, what did not work	20%

Part	What it contains	Time
Learning	What changed in how you work	10%

FW-C31-04 · The story-bank matrix · Original

- **Inputs:** 12 to 15 episodes from your work and the eight themes (plus values).
- **Outputs:** a matrix of episodes by theme with the strongest theme and one backup per episode, selection criteria, notes per story (five lines, numbers, two probes with answers, what to omit), and a coverage check.
- **Assumptions:** facts are verified and shareable.
- **Tradeoffs:** a larger bank covers more and costs more rehearsal time; eight to ten rehearsed stories is usually enough.
- **Failure modes:** a bank of scripts; one story for every theme; unverified numbers.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 4.

FW-C31-05 · The probe ladder · Original

- **Inputs:** a story.
- **Outputs:** two probes at each of three levels (detail, reasoning, counterfactual and limits) with prepared answers, the numbers at hand, and one thing that went wrong.
- **Assumptions:** you know the story well enough to be questioned for ten minutes.
- **Tradeoffs:** preparing probes takes time and prevents panic.
- **Failure modes:** inventing facts under pressure; defensiveness; changing the story's facts.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 3 and C31.7.

Level	Probe	Answer notes
1 Detail	What exactly did you do?	
2 Reasoning	Why that option? What data?	
3 Limits	What would you do differently? What did you not know?	

FW-C31-06 · The failure-story test · Original

- **Inputs:** a candidate failure story.
- **Outputs:** a pass or fail on five tests: real cost, your decision, an honest reason it seemed right, repair, and a behavior change with an example of it in use.
- **Assumptions:** you can tell it without blame.
- **Tradeoffs:** a real failure is uncomfortable and more credible.
- **Failure modes:** a disguised success; blaming others; no changed behavior.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 3 and IQ-C31-08.

FW-C31-07 · The situational answer · Original

- **Inputs:** a "what would you do if" prompt.
- **Outputs:** an answer with clarifying questions, the guiding principle, options and tradeoffs, a chosen first action with reasons, and a check on whether it worked.
- **Assumptions:** the interviewer will answer a clarifying question or two.
- **Tradeoffs:** a structured answer may be longer than the interviewer wants; signpost and stop.
- **Failure modes:** a single rule; refusing the premise; a list with no choice.
- **Worked example:** IQ-C31-11.

Steps: **Clarify** → **Principle** → **Options and tradeoffs** → **First action** → **How I'd check**.

FW-C31-08 · The values scenario frame · Original

- **Inputs:** a scenario with a conflict between a goal and an ethical or safety concern.
- **Outputs:** the facts and assumptions, stakeholders and harms (and reversibility), the pressure and the legitimate goal behind it, options beyond comply or refuse, relevant policy or principles, an action with escalation and honest communication, and the cost you accept.
- **Assumptions:** you would act on what you say.
- **Tradeoffs:** integrity can cost short-term results; naming the cost makes the answer credible.
- **Failure modes:** a speech; a binary; a hero story with no cost; a rule recited without judgment.
- **Worked example:** Worked example 5, IQ-C31-06, IQ-C31-11 and CS-C31-02.

Step	Question
Facts	What do I know and assume?
Stakeholders and harms	Who could be hurt, how badly, how reversibly?
Pressure and goal	What is driving it; can the goal be met another way?
Options	What else besides comply or refuse?
Principle	What do law, policy and product principles say?
Action	What first, whom to involve, how to communicate?
Cost	What might this cost me, and why accept it?

4. Answer architecture

The behavioral answer, for a 45-minute round

A behavioral round is usually three to five questions with probes. A typical flow: a two-minute introduction (or a short one), then three to four story questions of about three minutes each, each followed by five to eight minutes of probing, and your questions at the end.

Step	Minutes	What to produce
Opening: introduction or "why us"	3	The two-minute arc with three proof points
Story 1 with probes	10	Context, decision, action, result, learning; then three levels of probes
Story 2 with probes	10	A different theme; same structure
Story 3 with probes	10	A failure or values story; honest, specific
Situational or values question	5	The frame; a decision with a cost
Your questions	5	Two or three real questions about the role and team
Wrap and buffer	2	Close; room for an interviewer's follow-up

Pacing rules. Keep each initial answer to about three minutes and let the interviewer probe. If you run long, cut the context and keep the decision, your action and the learning. If the interviewer interrupts with a probe, answer it, then return briefly to the thread.

How to start an answer. Name the story in a sentence and say which question it answers: "I'll tell you about a launch I led that went wrong, since it taught me the most about speed and quality." Then context.

How to close an answer. One sentence of learning, then stop: "What changed for me is that I now agree the quality bar in writing before the date is set." Invite probing: "Happy to go into any part."

Type: introduction, motive and favorite product

Use the two-minute arc, evidence for the motive, and the favorite-product formula (user, job, two decisions, one critique).

Type: a story prompt (conflict, influence, ambiguity, customer, data, prioritization, leading)

Choose a bank story; context, decision, action, result, learning; prepare for probes.

Type: failure or weakness

Apply the failure-story test; real cost, owned decision, changed behavior.

Type: situational (what would you do if)

Clarify, principle, options, first action, how you'd check.

Type: values and judgment

The values frame: facts, harms, goal behind the pressure, options, principle, action, cost accepted.

Common interviewer interventions, and what to do

Interviewer says	What it means	What to do
"What was your role?"	Too much "we"	State your decisions and actions in "I"
"Why did you choose that?"	Reasoning probe	Name the options and the reason; admit the tradeoff
"What was the result?"	Evidence	Give the number and baseline, or say what you know
"What would you do differently?"	Learning	A concrete behavior, with an example of using it since
"Was that because of you?"	Attribution	Separate your contribution from other causes
"Have you faced something like this?"	Situational asks for a past	Offer a short real example
"What if the number were worse?"	Limits	Say what you would conclude and do

5. Worked examples

All five examples are **Illustrative** composites: the people, companies, numbers and events are invented (invented), built to show structure, and they must never be used as your own experience. Your stories must be true. Each shows the story as notes and as it might be told, with the signals an interviewer would take from it.

Worked example 1 — From a rambling introduction to a two-minute arc (Illustrative)

The weak version (summarized). "So I did my degree in economics, and then I did an internship, and then I got a job at a payments company where I worked on lots of things, dashboards mostly, and also some SQL, and then I moved to my current company, and now I work on a team that does onboarding, and I'm looking to move to product management because I like working with people and solving problems." It runs four minutes when spoken in full, mentions no result, and ends with a generic motive (invented). The interviewer learns where the candidate has been and nothing about what they can do.

Rebuild it (FW-C31-02). *Present with scope.* What you own and how big it is. *Past in two or three steps*, each with a reason and a proof point. *Future tied to the role.* *Hand over.*

The strong version (237 words, about 1 minute 50 seconds at an unhurried pace).

"I'm a product analyst on the onboarding team at a budgeting app with about 400,000 monthly users, and I own the metrics and experiments for the first seven days. I got here in three steps. I studied economics, and in my final year I ran a survey project for a campus startup, where I found I liked deciding what to ask more than analyzing the answers. That led to my first job, as an analyst at a payments company. I built the first funnel dashboard for merchant sign-up and found that 38% of merchants stopped at bank verification. I took it to the product manager, and with a designer we cut the form from 12 fields to 7; completion rose from 52% to 61%.

That was when I realized I wanted to own the decision, not only the analysis. Two years ago I moved to my current team, where I run about two experiments a month. The one I am proudest of changed our default notification settings: I showed that the old default raised opens and also doubled opt-outs, and the quieter default we shipped raised 90-day retention by 1.2 points. What I want next is to own a product area end to end, and that is why this role interests me: the team works on helping first-time investors, a problem I have spent the last year studying. I'm happy to go deeper on any of this."

What the arc does. Scope in the first sentence; three steps, each with a reason ("I liked deciding what to ask"); two proof points with numbers (the form change, the notification default) that invite probes; a motive supported by evidence; a hand-over. The interviewer now has two stories to ask about, which the candidate has prepared.

What to check. Every number must be true and shareable. Each proof point must be a story the candidate can tell for five more minutes with a decision, an action and a learning. If the form-change story was mostly the product manager's, the candidate says what they personally did.

What this shows. An introduction is a trailer for the stories: scope, an arc with reasons, and proof points that give the interviewer something to ask.

Worked example 2 — A conflict story built from notes (Illustrative)

The prompt. "Tell me about a time you disagreed with a colleague."

The notes (FW-C31-03).

- *Context:* My first launch as the lead analyst; the onboarding flow had six steps; a senior designer wanted to keep all six because each had a purpose; I believed two steps were hurting completion. Stakes: the flow decided whether a new user ever saw the product; completion was 41% (invented).
- *Decision:* Argue my view harder, escalate to the product manager, or propose a test that could settle it. I chose the test, because the designer's point (that each step helps later use) was plausible and I had only correlational data.
- *Action:* I asked the designer what each step was for and wrote down her reasons; found that two steps collected data used by a feature that only 9% of users reached; proposed an experiment with a version that moved those two steps to after first use; agreed on metrics together (completion as the goal, seven-day activation as the guardrail); she suggested a change to the copy that I added.

- **Result:** Completion rose from 41% to 47% and seven-day activation was flat (the interval for the change in activation included zero); we shipped the shorter flow and moved the two steps. The designer's copy change contributed a point of the lift.
- **Learning:** I had started by assuming the steps were the problem; I now start by asking what a step is for. Also, I now agree the success and guardrail metrics with the person I disagree with before running the test.

As told (about 2 minutes 30 seconds). "In my first launch as lead analyst, I disagreed with a senior designer about our onboarding flow. It had six steps and only 41% of new users finished. I thought two of the steps were costing us completions; she thought each step mattered. My choice was to argue harder, go to the product manager, or find a way to test it. I chose to test, because her point was plausible and I only had correlations. First I asked her what each step was for and wrote it down.

That showed that two steps collected data for a feature only 9% of users reached. I proposed an experiment moving those two steps to after first use, and we agreed together on the metrics: completion as the goal, and seven-day activation as a guardrail. She suggested a change to the copy, which I added. Completion rose from 41% to 47%, activation was flat, and we shipped it. About a point of that lift came from her copy change. What I took from it is to ask what a step is for before deciding it is the problem, and to agree the guardrail with the person I disagree with before the test."

Signals. Respect for the other view (asked, wrote it down, used her idea); a real decision (test, not escalate); evidence with limits ("the interval included zero"); credit given; learning that is behavioral. A weaker version: "We disagreed, I showed her the data, and she agreed." It would give no decision, no action and no learning.

Probes to prepare. What was the sample size and duration? What if activation had dropped? How did you feel when she pushed back? Did the result change her mind?

What this shows. The decision part (why test) is what makes it a PM story, and crediting the colleague makes the conflict credible.

Worked example 3 — A failure story and the probe ladder (Illustrative)

The prompt (invented story). "Tell me about a decision you got wrong."

The failure-story test (FW-C31-06). *Real cost:* a roadmap decision was delayed two weeks (invented) and a stakeholder lost some trust in my numbers. *My decision:* I reported a result without reconciling it. *Honest reason it seemed right:* the lift was large and it matched what the team expected. *Repair:* I told the stakeholder the same day I found the error, reran the analysis, sent a correction. *Behavior change:* I now reconcile any headline number against an independent source before sharing, and I have a short checklist.

As told (about 2 minutes 30 seconds). "Early in my current job I told the team that a new notification design had raised retention by 6 points. It was a big number and it matched what everyone hoped, and I shared it in a team meeting without checking it against anything else. Two days later I was preparing the readout for the director and noticed that the treatment

group's events were counted twice because of a logging change that shipped with the test. After correcting it, the lift was 1.1 points. I told my manager and the product manager that afternoon, sent a written correction, and reran the analysis with the engineer who owned the logging. The cost was real: a roadmap decision that had leaned on the 6 points was delayed by two weeks, and a stakeholder told me she would now want a second pair of eyes on my numbers. What I do differently is reconcile any headline figure against a second source before I share it, and I check event counts per user between groups. I used it last quarter, when a dashboard figure didn't match finance's; I found a definition difference before it went into a slide."

Probe ladder (FW-C31-05).

- *Level 1, detail.* "What exactly was wrong in the logging?" — "A new event fired once on the server and once on the client in the treatment arm; I found it by comparing events per user between arms, which were 1.9 times higher in treatment." "How did you tell people?" — "In person to my manager first, then a written note to the thread with the corrected number and the cause."
- *Level 2, reasoning.* "Why did you share before checking?" — "The number matched our hopes and I was keen to give good news; I treated plausibility as verification. I also didn't want to hold up a meeting." "How did you decide the corrected number was right?" — "Two independent counts agreed after the fix, and the engineer confirmed the event schema."
- *Level 3, counterfactual and limits.* "Would the decision have been different if the true figure had been known?" — "Probably the same direction but slower: 1.1 points was still positive, but smaller than the cost of one of the options, so they would have chosen differently." "Is there anything you still don't know?" — "Whether the logging error affected earlier tests; I checked the last three and found none."

What this shows. A failure with a real cost, an honest reason, a repair and a habit with evidence that it is used.

Worked example 4 — Building a story bank (Illustrative)

The inventory (FW-C31-04). A candidate with about two years of experience lists 12 episodes (invented): (1) the first funnel dashboard and form cut; (2) the notification default experiment; (3) the onboarding disagreement with a designer; (4) the double-counted events error; (5) a user-interview project that changed a feature's scope; (6) a launch that missed its date after an estimate was cut by management; (7) mentoring a new analyst; (8) a campus hackathon app with a team of four; (9) pushing back on a request to use a pre-checked subscription box; (10) a pricing-page test that failed; (11) helping support build a report that cut ticket time; (12) a quarter in which three requests competed for one engineer.

Selection. Keep episodes with a real decision, clear stakes, an outcome, a learning and a story you can tell truthfully for ten minutes. Drop (7) (little decision), (11) (mostly someone else's work) and (8) (too old and too far from the role), keeping 9.

Mapping to themes.

Theme	Primary story	Backup
Conflict	(3) the onboarding disagreement	(6) the missed date
Failure	(4) the double-counted events	(10) the failed pricing test
Influence without authority	(2) the notification default	(1) the form cut
Ambiguity	(5) the user-interview project	(12) the three requests
Customer focus	(5) the user-interview project	(1) the form cut
Data-driven decision	(2) the notification default	(10) the failed pricing test
Prioritization	(12) the three competing requests	(6) the missed date
Leading others	(6) the launch, where I coordinated four people	(1)
Values and judgment	(9) the pre-checked box	none yet

Coverage check. Nine themes and nine stories, with some stories carrying two themes. Gaps: no backup for values (develop (9) with a second angle, and look for a second episode); (5) carries two themes, so choose which to lead with in a given loop. No story appears more than twice as a primary.

Use the attribute map (FW-C31-01). For a loop at a company that publishes a leadership list including ownership, disagreement and commitment, and results (Amazon-type), lead with (3), (4) and (2); for a company stressing growth mindset (Microsoft-type), lead with (4), (10) and (5). The stories do not change; the order and emphasis do.

Write notes, not scripts. Each of the nine stories gets five lines (context, decision, action, result, learning), the key numbers, two probes with answers, and what to omit.

What this shows. Nine well-prepared stories cover the themes, and the bank is organized by decision and evidence, not by job title.

Worked example 5 — A values scenario: pressure to hit a number (Illustrative)

The prompt. "Your manager wants to hit this quarter's sign-up target by pre-checking a box that subscribes people to a weekly email. You think it is manipulative. What do you do?"

Apply the frame (FW-C31-08).

- **Facts.** What does the data say? A small test (invented): with the box pre-checked, sign-ups per 1,000 visitors rise from 80 to 101 (from 8.0% to 10.1%), but 7-day unsubscribes rise from 12% to 31%, and complaints triple. I also check the law and company policy: consent rules in several regions require opt-in for marketing email [V: GDPR Article 4(11) (clear affirmative action) and the ePrivacy Directive (opt-in for marketing email), as summarized in guidance].
- **Stakeholders and harms.** Users who did not intend to subscribe (annoyance, loss of trust); the company (complaints, spam reports, regulatory risk); the team's credibility.

- *The pressure and the legitimate goal.* The target is a growth number; the legitimate goal is more engaged subscribers.
- *The real effect.* Retained subscribers per 1,000 visitors after a week: before, $80 \times (1 - 0.12) = 70.4$; after, $101 \times (1 - 0.31) = 69.7$. The tactic produces no net gain and adds complaints and risk. It raises the number that is reported and not the number that matters (Goodhart, C05).
- *Options.* Comply; refuse; propose an opt-in design that improves the value proposition (show a sample email, explain the benefit), test it against the pre-checked version on retained subscribers and complaints, and report the retained-subscribers measure to leadership.
- *Principle.* A default that works against users' stated interests is a dark pattern (C10.10).
- *Action and escalation.* Talk to my manager first, privately, with the numbers; propose the test and a revised target definition (retained subscribers); if told to ship it anyway and it appears to violate policy or law, raise it with legal or the policy owner, in writing, and decline to implement what I believe is unlawful.
- *Cost I accept.* A harder conversation, a possible missed sign-up target this quarter, and the risk of being seen as difficult.

As told (about 2 minutes). "I would first check the facts, then talk to my manager with the numbers. In a small test, pre-checking the box raised sign-ups per thousand visitors from 80 to 101, but unsubscribes within a week went from 12% to 31%, so after a week we kept about 70 subscribers per thousand either way, with three times the complaints. So the tactic moves the number we report and not the number we want. I would propose an opt-in version that shows a sample of the email, test it against the pre-checked one on retained subscribers and complaints, and suggest we measure the target on retained subscribers. If I were told to ship the pre-checked box anyway and I believed it broke consent rules, I would raise it with legal in writing and not build it. It could cost us the sign-up target this quarter and some goodwill with my manager, and I would accept that."

What this shows. The answer does not preach: it finds the legitimate goal, measures the real effect, offers a better route and states the cost.

6. Baseline, Strong, Standout

Prompt: "Tell me about a time you disagreed with your manager."

Baseline answer

"Once my manager wanted to launch a feature and I thought we should wait. We talked about it, and in the end we found a compromise that worked for everyone. It taught me the importance of communication."

What is wrong: no context or stakes, no decision, no action, no result, no number; a generic learning. It gives the interviewer nothing to probe.

Strong answer

"Last year my manager wanted to launch a redesigned checkout in the same week as a pricing change. I was concerned that we could not tell which change caused any movement in conversion, and that a problem would be hard to diagnose. I raised it in our one-to-one with a specific example from an earlier launch where two changes overlapped and we spent two weeks untangling the result. She worried about missing a seasonal window. We agreed to stagger the launches by a week, with the checkout first, which cost her four days against the window. Conversion rose 2.1% on the checkout alone, and the pricing change a week later was read cleanly. What I took from it is to bring a concrete example and a proposal, not only a concern."

Standout answer

Everything in the Strong answer, plus:

"I want to be honest that I was partly wrong. When I raised it, I assumed the seasonal window was flexible. My manager showed me it was worth about 8% of the quarter's volume, and that changed my proposal: instead of delaying the pricing change by a week, we launched it to a tenth of users the same week so that we captured most of the window while keeping a clean read from the other nine tenths. That was her idea built on my concern. When we disagreed over the final design, she decided, and I committed: I helped write the launch plan even though I preferred a longer delay."

"The result was a clean read of both changes and 90% of the window's volume. What I changed afterward is that I now ask what a deadline is worth in numbers before I argue against it, and I agree in advance what evidence would make us reverse. When she asked what I would do differently, I said I would have brought the cost of the delay in numbers to the first conversation, not discovered it in the second."

What moves an answer up a band

From Baseline to Strong	From Strong to Standout
Names stakes, a decision, an action and a number	Admits where you were partly wrong and uses the other person's idea
Gives a concrete example and a proposal	Shows commitment after the decision went the other way
Offers a learning	Gives a behavioral change and its use since

7. Company lens

All claims describe what companies say publicly or what candidates commonly report, not insider knowledge. Interview formats and published values change [as of 2026-10] .

Company lens: Amazon [as of 2026-10]. Amazon publishes sixteen Leadership Principles on its careers site and describes using them every day Public [V: Amazon's Leadership Principles, as cited by several summaries]. Candidates commonly report that behavioral questions probe these principles, often with several rounds and detailed follow-ups Inferred. Practical consequence: prepare eight to ten stories with numbers and your personal decisions (ownership, dive deep, disagreeing and committing, delivering results), and expect repeated probing for detail; do not recite principle names.

Company lens: Google [as of 2026-10]. Google describes assessing general cognitive ability, role-related knowledge, leadership and an attribute called Googleyness (not to be confused with culture fit, by Google's own clarification) in its hiring materials Public [V: summaries citing Google's how-we-hire page; Google re:Work structured-interviewing guide]. Candidates commonly report structured behavioral questions about ambiguity, collaboration and leadership without authority Inferred. Practical consequence: choose stories with unclear goals and several stakeholders, show how you structured the problem and brought others along, and stay humble about what you did not know.

Company lens: Meta [as of 2026-10]. Meta's published values emphasize moving fast, long-term impact and direct communication Public [V: Meta's careers culture page, six core values]. Candidates commonly report questions about impact, speed and tradeoffs, and about giving and receiving direct feedback Inferred. Practical consequence: lead with results and numbers, show a speed-quality tradeoff you made and what it cost, and give an example of direct, respectful candor.

Company lens: Microsoft [as of 2026-10]. Microsoft's culture materials emphasize a growth mindset (learning and curiosity over knowing everything) and collaboration Public [V: Microsoft careers culture page]. Candidates commonly report questions about learning from mistakes, working across teams and customer focus Inferred. Practical consequence: include stories in which you changed your mind or learned something that changed your approach, and show how you helped others learn.

Company lens: Apple [as of 2026-10]. Apple does not publish a hiring rubric; candidates commonly report an emphasis on craft, attention to detail, collaboration across disciplines and discretion Inferred [unverified: candidate-reported]. Practical consequence: have a story about obsessing over a detail and its cost, one about protecting users or privacy against a business request, and be careful not to disclose confidential information from past employers in any story.

Company lens: Netflix [as of 2026-10]. Netflix publishes a culture memo (last updated June 2024) built on four principles, with candor among its values and managers expected to give people context Public [V: Netflix culture memo, June 2024] . Candidates commonly report questions on independent judgment, candid feedback and decisions made without waiting for approval Inferred . Practical consequence: prepare a story where you gave candid feedback to someone more senior, and one where you made a call on your own judgment and owned the outcome.

Company lens: Stripe [as of 2026-10]. Stripe publishes operating principles that include users first and moving with urgency and focus Public [V: Stripe careers pages, principles list; also quoted by The Pragmatic Engineer and Aced] , and is widely described as valuing clear thinking and writing Inferred [V: The Pragmatic Engineer, Inside Stripe's Engineering Culture Part 2 (strong culture of writing); Slab interview with Stripe's former Documentation Manager] . Candidates report behavioral questions on rigor and care for users, especially developers Inferred . Practical consequence: show stories with precise reasoning and care about the user's real problem, and be ready to explain a decision clearly in writing-style structure.

8. Common mistakes

#	Mistake	How to detect it	Fix
1	A rambling introduction	Four minutes, no arc	Present, past in steps with reasons, future, hand over
2	A generic motive for PM	"I like solving problems"	Evidence of what drew you and what you learned
3	All "we"	The interviewer cannot tell what you did	"I" for your decisions and actions; credit others
4	No decision	A story that is a sequence of events	State the options and why you chose
5	No numbers	"It went well"	A figure with a baseline, or an honest "I don't have it"
6	A fake failure or weakness	"I work too hard"	A real cost, an owned decision, a changed habit
7	Reciting company principles	"That shows ownership"	Tell the story; let them label it
8	Inventing detail	A number that changes under probing	Use only what is true; say what you don't recall
9	Defensiveness under probing	Arguing with the follow-up	Acknowledge the flaw; say what you now think

#	Mistake	How to detect it	Fix
10	Answering what you want to tell	A story for a different theme	Answer the question asked; say so if you pivot

9. Mental models applied

Four models, each tied to a decision in this chapter. `[[inversion]]` and `[[goodharts-law]]` are from C02, and the pre-mortem (`[[pre-mortem]]`) is from C02.

Steelmanning (`MM-steelman`). State the other side's position in its strongest form before responding. In a conflict story it shows respect and understanding: "Her point was that each step helps later use, which was plausible," and it makes your resolution credible.

Hanlon's razor (`MM-hanlon`). Do not attribute to malice what is adequately explained by misunderstanding or competing constraints

[V: Robert J. Hanlon, in Arthur Bloch, *Murphy's Law Book Two*, 1980, page 52; earlier similar lines: Heinlein, *Logic of Empire*, 1941; Goethe, 1774. The book wording is an adaptation of the original, which says stupidity]. Tell conflict stories as differences in information and incentives, not villains.

Inversion (`MM-inversion`, see `[[inversion]]`, C02). To prepare, ask how an answer would fail: no decision, no number, all "we," a probe you cannot answer. Then fix each in the story.

The pre-mortem (`MM-pre-mortem`, see `[[pre-mortem]]`, C02). For a values scenario, imagine the decision was regretted a year later and ask why; the answers (a missing fact, a harm you ignored) are what to check now.

Engineering, design and data-science perspectives

Your stories involve other people, and they will describe the same events differently. Test each story against how they would tell it.

- **Engineering.** An engineer in your story would care about what you asked of them and whether you listened to the constraint. If you say you "convinced engineering," ask whether they would say they were persuaded or pushed. Credit their contribution in the story.
- **Design and research.** A designer would care about whether you took their reasoning seriously. Tell conflict stories so that the designer would recognize their own view in your account of it.
- **Data science.** A data scientist would check the numbers and the claim about causation. Be precise about what the data showed and what it did not.
- **Your manager.** A manager would check scope and credit: did you do this, or did you only report it? Do not claim a decision that was your manager's; describe your part.

Checklist: before you walk into a behavioral round

1. Do I have a two-minute introduction with a clear arc and three proof points I can expand on?
2. Do I have honest, specific reasons for product management and for this company and role?
3. Do I have eight to ten stories, each with notes on context, decision, action, result and learning, and verified numbers?
4. Does my bank cover conflict, failure, influence, ambiguity, customer focus, a data-driven decision, prioritization, leading and a values moment?
5. For each story, can I say what I did, as opposed to what the team did?
6. Have I prepared two probes at each of three levels for every story, and one thing that went wrong?
7. Do I have a real failure, a real weakness and a values story that cost something?
8. Have I rehearsed aloud, timed to two to three minutes, and mapped stories to the company's published attributes without reciting them?

10. Case studies

CS-C31-01 · The answer that said "we" forty times · Illustrative · Beginner

Fictional composite. Every number is invented (invented).

Situation. A candidate with two years of experience practices the prompt "Tell me about a project you led" with a friend who has interviewed candidates. The candidate talks for five minutes about a redesign of a reporting dashboard.

Constraints. A project the candidate cared about; a habit of describing team outcomes; no practice at timing.

Data. The friend counts: "we" appears about 40 times and "I" six times; there is no number in the story; the friend cannot say what the candidate decided; the story's learning is "teamwork is important." The friend's note: "I don't know if you led it or watched it."

Problem definition. As an observable problem: "The story contains no decision, no personal action and no result, so the listener can infer nothing about the candidate's judgment."

Analysis. The content was probably good. The telling hid it. Using the anatomy (FW-C31-03): *Context* took three minutes; *Decision* was missing; *Action* was narrated as "we"; *Result* had no number; *Learning* was generic. The probe test: ask "what did you personally decide?" and "what was the result?"; the candidate answers both well when asked, which shows the material exists. The rewrite: two sentences of context (the dashboard took four minutes to load and 60% of managers stopped using it); the decision (rebuild everything or cut it to five key charts, and I chose to cut, after interviewing six managers); the action (the

interviews, the proposal, getting the data team to build a cached view); the result (load time to 8 seconds, weekly use from 40% to 71% of managers); the learning (talk to users before choosing scope).

Options.

Option	Optimizes	Costs
A. Keep the story as it is	Comfort	No signal
B. Rewrite with the five parts and numbers, and rehearse to three minutes	Signal	Work to recall the numbers
C. Switch to a different story	Possibly a better story	Loses the stronger material

Tradeoffs. B costs an evening and turns a good project into a good story; C is unnecessary.

Decision. Choose B. Write the five-part notes, replace each "we" with the specific "I" or a named role where true, add the baseline and result numbers, and time it at 2 minutes 40 seconds. Prepare two probes at each level.

Outcome. In this fictional scenario the rewritten story ran 2 minutes 40 seconds with 14 uses of "I" for personal actions and 9 of "we" for team results, included three numbers, and survived five minutes of probing by the friend (invented).

Alternative outcomes. If the candidate had in fact made no decisions on the project, the honest choice would have been a different story. A made-up decision would have collapsed under the probe "why not rebuild everything?" The lesson: a story is evidence of what you did; tell the decision, the action and the number, and use only what is true.

CS-C31-02 · Johnson & Johnson, 1982: a values decision with a known cost · Verified · Advanced

Sources (types): a contemporaneous Fortune article, "The fight to save Tylenol" by Thomas Moore (29 November 1982), read in full; the Food and Drug Administration's compliance policy guide on tamper-resistant packaging (CPG 450.500) and the Federal Register notices of the 1982 rule; a university ethics case study of the recall (University of New Mexico, Daniels Fund Ethics Initiative), for later share figures and the company's Credo; and educational and journalistic summaries for the 1983 anti-tampering law. Sources differ on some figures (noted below), and none gives the internal deliberations in detail. The analysis is the author's. The case is used to show the shape of a values decision, not to praise or judge a company. Re-read in October 2026.

Situation. In late September 1982 seven people in the Chicago area died after taking Extra-Strength Tylenol capsules that had been laced with cyanide, in what investigators concluded was tampering after the bottles reached store shelves, since the poisoned bottles came from different factories. Tylenol, made by a Johnson & Johnson subsidiary, was a leading pain reliever, with a market share reported as about 35 to 37 percent, and by one account accounted for 15 to 20 percent of the company's profits. Johnson & Johnson's chairman, James Burke, took charge of the response personally, met the FBI and the FDA in

Washington on the Monday after the first weekend, and, on the Monday after the second weekend, formed a strategic group of key executives to oversee the work of rebuilding the brand [V: Fortune, 1982]. The company used the media to warn the public and urged people to switch to tablets [V: Fortune, 1982]. Burke began to advocate recalling all Extra-Strength capsules, but the FBI and the FDA counseled against a precipitous recall: the FBI feared it would tell the perpetrator he was winning, and the FDA feared it would cause more public anxiety than it would relieve [V: Fortune, 1982].

On the following Tuesday (5 October, according to reference summaries), after what appeared to be a copycat strychnine poisoning in California, the FDA agreed with Burke that all Tylenol capsules should be recalled nationwide: about 31 million bottles with a retail value of over \$100 million, a cost the company estimated at about \$100 million before taxes, which cut third-quarter earnings per share from 78 cents the year before to 51 cents (Fortune). By late November 1982 the company had a new tamper-resistant package and was preparing to bring capsules back, and sales of Tylenol products had initially fallen about 80% [V: Fortune, 29 November 1982]; accounts differ on exactly when the product returned to the shelves. Tylenol's share is reported to have fallen from 37% of the over-the-counter pain reliever market to about 7% by late 1982 and to have recovered to about 30% within six months (the University of New Mexico case study), while other accounts give 8% and about a year [V: UNM case study; secondary accounts]. The FDA published final tamper-resistant packaging regulations for most over-the-counter drugs on 5 November 1982, about five weeks after the first deaths, and amended them in 1989 to require two tamper-resistant features for two-piece capsules unless they are sealed by a tamper-resistant technology [V: FDA CPG 450.500; Federal Register]. Congress passed an anti-tampering law in 1983, making product tampering a federal crime [V: reference summaries].

Constraints. A product central to the company's profits and identity; uncertainty about whether the contamination was local or national, and who was responsible; public fear; a media environment moving by the hour; a company credo that put customers first, which the committee used as a guide, according to later case studies (Fortune's contemporaneous account does not mention it); and the fact that the poisoning occurred after the product left the company's control, which would have allowed a narrower response.

Data. As reported: the deaths, the share and profit figures, the recall's scale and cost, the earnings effect, the share recovery, the packaging change and the rule change. Accounts differ on the exact share figures (Fortune: a 35% share of a \$1 billion analgesic market in 1982, and an estimated 7% of J&J's worldwide sales and 15% to 20% of its profits in 1981; the New Mexico case study: 37%). Fortune ties the nationwide capsule recall to the California incident, and reports that company surveys found 94% of consumers aware of the poisonings, 87% of Tylenol users saying the maker was not responsible, and 61% saying they were unlikely to buy Extra-Strength capsules in future [V: Fortune, 1982].

Problem definition. *The author's reading.* The company faced a choice between a narrow response (withdrawal in Chicago, warnings) that would limit cost and a broad one (a national recall) that would cost far more and remove any chance that another person would be harmed. As an observable problem: "Seven people had died, the cause was unknown to the public, and further harm was possible."

Analysis. *The author's analysis, using the values frame (FW-C31-08).*

Facts first. The company did not wait for certainty about the source of the problem; it acted on the risk to people while investigation went on, and it cooperated with authorities and the press.

Stakeholders and harms. The primary stakeholders were customers who could be harmed by an irreversible event (death), then retailers, employees and shareholders. The harm to customers was severe and irreversible; the harm to the company, though large, was financial and recoverable.

The pressure and the legitimate goal. The pressure was financial and reputational; the legitimate goal was to protect people and the brand's long-term trust. These were not opposed over the long run, as the later recovery suggests, though no one could know that at the time.

Options beyond comply or refuse. A regional recall; a national recall of capsules only; a national recall of all Tylenol products; a warning without a recall. In the sources read, Burke advocated a national recall of capsules early in the week and the FBI and FDA initially advised against it; the national recall followed the California incident, and a regional recall is not documented [V: Fortune, 1982].

Principle. The credo of the company, as the case studies describe it, put the people who use its products first. Whether a credo drove the decision or was invoked afterward is debated; Fortune's contemporaneous account, which quotes Burke at length, does not mention it, and the sources do not settle the question.

Action and communication. Public warnings, daily updates to the media, quick work on tamper-resistant packaging and a reintroduction.

The cost accepted. About \$100 million pretax in 1982 dollars, an earnings fall and, for a time, the collapse of the brand's share. The recovery was not certain at the time of the decision.

What this does and does not show. It shows a decision with a large and known cost taken for the safety of others, and it shows that actions with real cost can be consistent with long-term interest, though that cannot be promised. It does not show that doing the right thing always pays, and it is the output of a company's judgment with advice and a regulator's agreement, not one person's. For a candidate, the lesson is structural: say what the harm was, what the pressure was, what options there were, what you chose, and what it cost.

Options. *The author's reconstruction of choices the company could have faced; not a record of its deliberations.*

Option	Optimizes	Costs
A. A regional withdrawal and warnings	Lower cost; targeted	Risk of further harm elsewhere; weaker trust if more cases occur
B. A national recall of the affected product (capsules) and a rapid move to tamper-resistant packaging	Safety and trust	About \$100 million; sales collapse; operational effort

Option	Optimizes	Costs
C. A national recall of all Tylenol products	Maximum precaution	Higher cost; loss of the non-affected forms

Tradeoffs. B gave the strongest assurance at a cost the company could bear; A saved money at the risk of harm and loss of trust; C went beyond what the evidence required.

Decision. As documented, the company recalled all Tylenol capsules nationwide and reintroduced the product in tamper-resistant packaging.

Outcome. Reported: the recall, the earnings fall, the share collapse and recovery, the packaging innovation and new rules, and the case's later use as a model of crisis response [V: Fortune; UNM case study; FDA]. Families of three of the victims filed lawsuits against Johnson & Johnson in 1983 [V: law-firm page]; the sources read here do not give their outcome.

Alternative outcomes. *Inference.* Had more people been harmed after a narrow response, the cost in lives and in the company's standing would have been far larger. A reader should be careful with hindsight: the company's choice looks obvious now and was uncertain and expensive then. The method to carry away for your own values stories: name the harm, the pressure and the legitimate goal behind it, the options, what you chose, what it cost you, and what you would say if it had not worked out.

11. Interview questions and model answers

Twelve questions. Every model answer is an **Illustrative** composite: the people, products, numbers and events are invented (invented) to show structure, and none may be used as your own experience; your stories must be true. Each model answer is given as the story you would tell, in notes-then-telling form, followed by the signals it gives. Each ends with follow-ups, which here are the probes an interviewer is likely to ask, and answers to them. Company settings are the typical prompts for that company and describe no internal practice. The answers are fuller than a first pass in a real round.

IQ-C31-01 · Beginner · behavioral · BE

Prompt. Tell me about yourself.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** A chronological recitation of the résumé.
- **Strong:** A two-minute arc with scope, steps with reasons and a link to the role.
- **Standout:** Plants three specific proof points with numbers that invite probes, shows a motive supported by evidence, and ends with a hand-over.

Model answer. *(A composite candidate from operations, to show a different path from Worked example 1.)* "I'm an associate on the operations analytics team at a logistics start-up, where I own the weekly reporting on delivery delays for about 12,000 deliveries a week. I got here in three steps. I started in customer support for a food-delivery company, where I

noticed the same five complaints every week and began tagging them; that tagging showed that 31% of contacts were about one confusing status message. I wrote up the finding and the product team changed the message, and contacts about it fell by about half. That was the first time I saw how one decision could change a lot of people's day, and it made me want to be the person making it.

I then moved to analytics, where I built the delay report and found that two warehouses caused 40% of late deliveries; I proposed a change to cutoff times that the operations lead tried, and late deliveries at those sites fell from 14% to 9%. Most recently I've started running small experiments on notification wording with our product team. What I want now is to own a product area, and your team's work on delivery tracking is a problem I know from the support side and from the data side. I'm happy to go deeper on any of those." About 230 words.

Signals. Scope; an arc with reasons; three proof points (the tagging, the delay report, the experiments); a motive with evidence; a hand-over.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** You said you want to own a product area. What makes you think you're ready? **A.** "I've owned decisions at small scale: the status message change and the cutoff-time trial were my proposals, and I followed them to a measured result. What I haven't done is carry a roadmap through a quarter of competing priorities, and that's what I want to learn. In the experiments I'm running now, I've started deciding with the product manager what we will and won't test."
- **Q.** Tell me more about the tagging project. What did you personally do? **A.** "I built the tag list from a sample of 300 contacts, trained two colleagues to use it, tagged about 2,000 contacts over three weeks and wrote the summary. The product manager and a designer rewrote the message; I measured contacts for six weeks after." (Then continue with numbers and what went wrong: the first tag list had overlapping categories and I had to redo 200 contacts.)

IQ-C31-02 · Beginner · behavioral · BE

Prompt. Why product management, and why this company and role?

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I like solving problems and working with people; your company is the leader in its field."
- **Strong:** Gives evidence for the motive and one or two concrete reasons for the company.
- **Standout:** Shows the realities of the work have been understood, connects a specific company fact to a specific personal fact, and offers what the candidate would examine first in the role.

Model answer. "Two things pulled me to product. One: in my current role I kept being the person who found the problem and then had to hand it to someone else to decide, and I realized I wanted the deciding part: what to build, for whom, and what not to build. Two: the work I enjoy most is the unglamorous part, like deciding which of three reasonable requests

gets the one engineer. In a recent quarter I had to say no to two stakeholders and wrote them each a short note with the reasoning; I found I liked the discipline of that. I also know what I would be giving up: less time for analysis and more time in conversations I can't always win.

"For this company and role: I use your product weekly, and I've tried the new sharing flow, which I think handles a real problem, the awkward step of sending to someone who has no account, in a way that most of your competitors do not. I've also read your published principles about putting users first, and my own best work, the status-message change, came from reading user complaints, not dashboards. For this role, I would want to understand first how new users reach their first shared item, because that is where I'd expect the biggest gap."

Signals. Evidence for the motive; awareness of the costs of the job; a specific, honest reason for the company; a first question for the role.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** Lots of people say they want to be a PM. What would make you different? **A.** "I can't speak for others, but I can show what I've done: I've made small product decisions with evidence and owned the result, I've said no with reasons, and I've gotten it wrong at least once and fixed my habits. I'd rather you test that than take my word."
- **Q.** What do you think the hardest part of this job is? **A.** "Deciding with incomplete information while people with more context disagree with you. The skill, I think, is writing down what would change your mind, and committing until then. I'm still building it, and I've found that stating the reversal condition up front helps."

IQ-C31-03 · Intermediate · behavioral · BE

Prompt. Tell me about a time you disagreed with an engineer about scope.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "We disagreed and then compromised."
- **Strong:** Context, the decision, an action showing listening and a result.
- **Standout:** Represents the engineer's view fairly, finds a cheaper test, credits their idea, states a result with a number and a behavioral learning.

Model answer. *Notes.* Context: a feature to let users export their data; I wanted export in three formats at launch; the engineer said one format would take two weeks and three would take seven; the launch was tied to a partner event in five weeks (invented). Decision: insist on three formats, accept one, or find out which formats mattered. Action: I asked what drove the cost (conversion code for two formats); I checked with support and found that 86% of export requests last quarter were for one format; I proposed launching with that format and a request form for the others; the engineer suggested making the form collect which format and why, which gave us data. Result: launched in two and a half weeks; the form collected 140 requests in a month, of which 61% asked for one second format, which we built next; no missed event. Learning: ask what drives the cost, and check who actually needs each option, before arguing about scope.

Told (about 2 minutes 20 seconds). "We were building a data export feature. I wanted three formats at launch; the engineer said one would take two weeks and three would take seven, and we had five weeks until a partner event. I could have insisted, accepted his view, or tried to learn what mattered. I asked what made the extra formats expensive, which was conversion code, and then I checked support's tickets: 86% of export requests were for a single format. So I proposed launching with that one and a request form for the rest, and he suggested the form ask which format and why, so we'd learn. We launched in two and a half weeks. In a month the form had 140 requests, 61% for one other format, which we built next. What I took away is to ask what drives the cost and who really needs each option before debating scope."

Signals. A fair account of his view; a decision to learn; a number-backed resolution; shared credit.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if the engineer had disagreed with your proposal? **A.** "I'd have asked what evidence would change his mind and offered to look at it together; if we still disagreed, the decision on scope is mine as the PM, but I'd tell him my reasoning and ask him to flag the risk in writing so that we'd both be clear."
- **Q.** How do you know the 86% figure was reliable? **A.** "It was last quarter's tickets, about 220 of them, which is a decent sample, but it measures who asked for exports, not who would use them. That's why I wanted the form: it gave a second view, and it matched."

IQ-C31-04 · Intermediate · behavioral · BE · Amazon

Prompt. Tell me about a time you disagreed with a decision and committed anyway.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I didn't agree, but I did what my manager asked."
- **Strong:** States the disagreement with evidence, voices it, and commits fully after the decision.
- **Standout:** Shows candid advocacy before the decision, wholehearted execution after it, a protective action (monitoring or a reversal condition), an honest result including that the decision was right or wrong, and learning.

Model answer. *Notes.* Context: my manager decided to launch a redesigned pricing page to everyone without a test, to meet a quarter-end date; I had seen two earlier redesigns lower conversion (invented). Decision: argue until overruled, then commit with a safeguard, or quietly disengage. Action: I wrote a one-page note with the two earlier results, a proposal for a 10% holdback for two weeks at a cost of about 2% of the page's quarterly volume, and the risk if the page was worse (a month at a lower rate, about \$90,000 in lost revenue); my manager read it, weighed the quarter-end date, and decided to launch to everyone. I said I disagreed and would commit. I then built the launch plan, set up a daily conversion check with a threshold for rollback, and told the team the decision was made and why. Result: conversion on the new page was 3% lower in week one; we hit the threshold on day five, rolled back and shipped a revised page two weeks later that tested 4% higher. The cost was

about a week at the lower rate. Learning: I was right about the risk, and my manager was right that the date mattered, so I now bring the date's cost in numbers to the first conversation; and I protect a decision I disagree with by agreeing the rollback condition in advance.

Told (about 2 minutes 40 seconds). "My manager decided to launch a redesigned pricing page to everyone, without a test, to hit a quarter-end date. I disagreed: I had seen two earlier redesigns lower conversion. I could argue until I was overruled, commit with a safeguard, or quietly disengage. Before the decision I wrote a one-page note with the two earlier results and a proposal to hold back 10% of traffic for two weeks, which would cost about 2% of the page's quarterly volume; if the page was worse we would lose about \$90,000 over a month. My manager weighed the date and decided to launch to everyone.

I said I still disagreed and that I would commit, and I did: I wrote the launch plan, set up a daily conversion check with an agreed rollback threshold, and told the team the decision was made and why. In week one conversion was 3% lower; we hit the threshold on day five, rolled back, and shipped a revised page two weeks later that tested 4% higher. The cost was about a week at the lower rate. I was right about the risk and my manager was right that the date mattered, so now I bring the date's cost in numbers to the first conversation, and I agree a rollback condition in advance for any decision I disagree with."

Signals. Candor before the decision, commitment after, a protective mechanism, honest accounting.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** Did you really commit, or did you hope it would fail? **A.** "I wanted it to work. I took the launch plan and the monitoring personally; I would have been unhappy to be proved right at the company's expense. When it dipped, I did not say 'I told you so'; I used the threshold we had agreed to."
- **Q.** What if the rollback threshold had not been reached and the page had hurt a little? **A.** "Then I'd have kept watching, shared the numbers weekly and asked whether the date benefit outweighed the loss. The agreement beforehand was that a drop of more than 2.5% for three days triggers rollback; below that we'd learn and iterate."

IQ-C31-05 · Intermediate · behavioral · BE · Apple

Prompt. Tell me about a product detail you obsessed over, and what it cost.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I'm a perfectionist; I care about every detail."
- **Strong:** A specific detail, why it mattered to users, and a named cost.
- **Standout:** Shows judgment about which detail was worth the cost, quantifies both, admits where the obsession was or wasn't justified, and shows how the candidate now decides what to obsess over.

Model answer. *Notes.* Context: the empty state of a new user's first screen in a note-taking app: a blank page with a cursor (invented). Users who landed there had a 46% chance of leaving without writing anything. Decision: ship the planned release on time with the blank screen, or spend time on the first-run experience. Action: I watched ten new users start (six stared at the blank page); I tried 12 variants of the first line and an example note; two engineers and a designer spent five days on it, which pushed a smaller sharing improvement to the next release. The cost was a delay of that improvement by two weeks, five person-days and a lot of my time on wording. Result: first-session note creation rose from 54% to 63%, and support contacts about "how to start" fell by about 18%. Not everything I obsessed over paid off: I spent a day on an animation that tests showed no one noticed, and I cut it. Learning: I now decide what to obsess over by asking where the user's attention is and where the drop-off is; the detail has to sit on the path that matters.

Signals. Observation of users; a priced tradeoff; honesty about waste; a rule for choosing.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** How did you decide it was worth delaying the sharing improvement? **A.** "I compared: the sharing improvement was expected to help about 4% of users; the first-run problem touched every new user, and 46% were leaving at that screen. A two-week delay to the smaller item was a cost I could explain to the team."
- **Q.** Where did you go too far? **A.** "The animation. I judged by my own taste and it did not change behavior in the test. I cut it, and it taught me to test the detail with users before spending engineering time on polish."

IQ-C31-06 · Hard · behavioral · BE · Apple

Prompt. Describe a time you protected user privacy against a business request.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I told them it was wrong and they agreed."
- **Strong:** Names the request, the harm, the alternative offered and the outcome.
- **Standout:** Applies a clear frame (facts, harms, goal behind the request, options), proposes a route to the legitimate goal, accepts and states a real cost, escalates properly, and reflects honestly.

Model answer. *Notes (FW-C31-08).* Context: a partner team asked me to share a list of 40,000 users' email addresses with a marketing partner for a co-promotion, expecting about \$60,000 in revenue (invented). Users had not agreed to partner marketing. Facts: I checked our privacy policy and consent records; the policy did not cover it. Harm: users' addresses shared without consent; a trust and legal risk. Goal behind the request: reach likely customers. Options: share anyway, refuse, or offer an alternative.

Decision: offer a consent-based version and refuse the list. Action: I proposed an in-product message to our users offering the partner's promotion with an opt-in, and a matched audience measured in aggregate; I wrote this up for the product lead and the privacy owner; the partner team was unhappy: the opt-in route would take three weeks and was expected to reach about 15% of the list. Result: the opt-in drew about 6,200 users, produced about

\$11,000 in the first month and no complaints; the original plan was dropped. Cost: three weeks' delay, about 80% less revenue in the short term, and some frustration with me. Learning: bring an alternative that serves the goal, not only an objection, and get the privacy owner involved early.

Signals. A frame applied; a legitimate goal respected; a priced cost; a proper escalation.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if your manager had overruled you and told you to share the list? **A.** "I'd have asked for the decision in writing from someone with authority over privacy, and told my manager that I would not send it myself if I believed it violated policy or law. I would have escalated to the privacy owner or legal, with the facts, and accepted the consequences for me."
- **Q.** Were you sure it was against policy? **A.** "I checked the policy and consent records first, and asked the privacy owner to confirm. If it had been covered, I'd have raised the harm to users as a concern and suggested notice, but I would not have said it was prohibited."

IQ-C31-07 · Intermediate · behavioral · BE · Google

Prompt. Tell me about a time you worked on an ambiguous problem.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "The goal wasn't clear, so I asked questions until it was."
- **Strong:** Shows how the candidate structured the problem and moved forward.
- **Standout:** States assumptions, uses cheap tests, narrows with evidence, brings stakeholders along, decides what to ignore, and shows what changed as understanding improved.

Model answer. *Notes.* Context: I was asked to "improve activation" for a small-business invoicing tool with no agreed definition of activation and three stakeholders with three ideas (invented). Decision: pick an idea, or define the problem first. Action: I proposed a working definition (a user who sends one invoice within seven days), checked it against retention (users who sent an invoice in week one were 3.1 times more likely to be active at day 60); listed three hypotheses for why users did not send one (they did not know how, they had no customer ready, they feared mistakes); ran a cheap test of each: a five-user observation (for the first), a survey of 200 non-senders (for the second), and a "preview invoice" prototype (for the third); the survey showed that 54% of non-senders had no customer ready, which surprised the stakeholders who had assumed the product was too hard; I agreed with them to test a "sample invoice" feature first. I deliberately set aside two ideas (a rewards program and a redesigned dashboard) with the reasons written down. Result: sample invoice use rose and seven-day activation went from 22% to 27%. Learning: define the term with data before choosing a solution, and write down what you are setting aside and why.

Signals. Structure under ambiguity; assumptions made explicit; cheap tests; stakeholders involved; discipline in what to ignore.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** How did you pick the working definition? **A.** "I looked for a behavior early in the first week that predicted day-60 activity; sending an invoice did, with a 3.1 times difference. I told the stakeholders it was a working definition we would revisit, and I checked it against another cohort later."
- **Q.** What would you have done with no data? **A.** "I'd have used interviews to find the first moment a user gets value and defined activation as reaching it, and then measured how many reach it. The data would have refined it afterward."

IQ-C31-08 · Intermediate · behavioral · BE · Meta

Prompt. Tell me about a time you moved fast and it went wrong.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I worked quickly, a bug got through, and I fixed it."
- **Strong:** Names the tradeoff made, the failure, the repair and the lesson.
- **Standout:** Shows why speed seemed right, quantifies the damage and the response time, owns the decision, and shows a lasting practice that preserves speed.

Model answer. *Notes.* Context: a one-line change to the sign-up form that I believed was safe, shipped on a Friday afternoon to hit a weekly goal (invented). I skipped the usual staged rollout. Decision: wait until Monday and ramp, or ship now. Why speed seemed right: the change was tiny, the team had a streak of weekly releases, and nothing in the test environment failed. What happened: for users on one older mobile browser (about 7% of sign-ups) the form's button stopped working; sign-ups from that group fell to near zero for 90 minutes before support noticed; about 1,100 users could not sign up.

Repair: I rolled the change back within 20 minutes of the first report, wrote to the support team and affected users, and added an automatic alert for sign-up drops by browser. Cost: about 1,100 failed sign-ups, a night of the team's attention and some trust. Learning: the speed I valued was real, and what protected it was a staged rollout behind a flag (1%, then 10%) and an alert; since then every change to sign-up ships to 1% first, and releases still go weekly. I own that I skipped the staging to hit a streak.

Signals. Honest tradeoff; quantified damage; ownership; a practice that keeps speed.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** Why did you skip the staging? **A.** "The change looked trivial and I was thinking about the streak, which was not a good reason. I treated 'small' as 'safe.' Small changes break things as often as big ones when the environment differs, which was an older browser I had not tested."
- **Q.** Would you do anything differently about the 90 minutes it took to notice? **A.** "Yes: the alert by browser I added would have caught it in minutes, and I'd also have asked support to flag any unusual spike in sign-up contacts. Detection speed matters more than being right the first time."

IQ-C31-09 · Hard · behavioral · BE · Netflix

Prompt. Tell me about a time you gave candid feedback to someone more senior than you.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I told my director I disagreed, and he appreciated it."
- **Strong:** Specific feedback, delivered thoughtfully, with an outcome.
- **Standout:** Shows preparation and respect (private, specific, evidence, a proposal), handles a negative reaction, accepts the cost, and shows a pattern of candor with care.

Model answer. *Notes.* Context: in a planning review, a director presented a slide saying a feature had "raised retention by 8%," based on a comparison of users who used the feature with those who did not (invented). I believed it overstated the effect because heavier users were more likely to use it. Decision: say nothing, raise it in the meeting, or talk to the director privately. Action: I looked at the data first and found that after matching users by prior activity, the lift was about 2%; I asked for 15 minutes the same day, said that I wanted to check my reading of the slide before the next review, showed the matched comparison and said that the 8% was probably selection; I proposed a holdout test and offered to run the analysis. The director was irritated at first ("this was already in the deck") and then asked for the analysis; the slide was corrected before it went to the executive team. Cost: some tension that week, and a colleague told me later that I should have mentioned it before the meeting. Learning: next time I raise concerns with data before a meeting, not after, and I always bring a proposed fix. We have worked well since, and he asks for my review of numbers before he presents.

Signals. Candor with care; preparation; a proposal; accepting the cost; a good relationship afterward.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if he had refused to change it? **A.** "I'd have asked what would convince him, offered the holdout, and, if the number were going to drive a significant decision, told him that I would feel obliged to raise the caveat with the people relying on it. I would do that openly, not behind his back."
- **Q.** How do you phrase feedback to a senior person? **A.** "I start with what I want to understand, show the evidence, say what I think it means without declaring him wrong, and propose a next step. 'I want to check whether I'm reading this right' opens the door better than 'this is wrong.'"

IQ-C31-10 · Intermediate · behavioral · BE · Microsoft

Prompt. Tell me about a time you changed your mind about a product decision because of new information.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I thought one thing and then learned another, so I changed."
- **Strong:** States the original belief, the new evidence, the change and its effect.

- **Standout:** Shows genuine attachment to the original view, how the candidate sought disconfirming evidence, how the change was communicated and what it says about the candidate's learning habits.

Model answer. *Notes.* Context: I was convinced that power users wanted advanced filters in a reporting tool, because they were the loudest in feedback and our top accounts were power users (invented). I had written the spec and told my manager the feature would be the quarter's headline. Decision: build as planned, or test the assumption. New information: before the build, I ran six interviews with newer users to check a different question and found that four of six could not find the basic filter at all; usage data then showed that 63% of new accounts never applied any filter in the first month. Action: I told my manager that the evidence contradicted my plan and showed both sets of numbers; we agreed to build a simpler first-use filter flow first and defer advanced filters; I told the power users why, and offered them an early look at the advanced version later. Result: filter use in the first month rose from 37% to 58% of new accounts; the advanced filters shipped one quarter later and were used by 11% of accounts, which was lower than I had expected. Learning: the loudest users are not the largest group, and I now ask for evidence that would contradict my belief before I commit a spec, and I check how many users each request represents.

Signals. Real attachment to the first view; seeking disconfirming evidence; clean communication of the change; a durable habit.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** Was it hard to tell your manager you had been wrong? **A.** "A little: I had been publicly confident. It was easier because I brought the numbers and a new plan, and he was more interested in the plan than in my earlier view. I've found the cost of changing your mind early is far smaller than the cost of shipping the wrong thing."
- **Q.** How did you know you weren't over-reacting to six interviews? **A.** "I didn't, which is why I checked it with the usage data from all new accounts: 63% never used a filter. Six interviews raised the question; the data sized it."

IQ-C31-11 · Hard · behavioral · BE

Prompt. A launch is tomorrow, and you discover a defect that corrupts the export for about 3% of users. What do you do?

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "I'd delay the launch," or "I'd launch and fix it later."
- **Strong:** Clarifies, weighs the harm and the cost of delay, and chooses.
- **Standout:** Uses the situational structure and the values frame: facts first, harm and reversibility, options such as a partial launch or disabling the feature, honest communication, a decision with a cost, and how it would be checked.

Model answer. *Clarify (two or three questions).* How sure are we of the 3% and what does corrupts mean: lost data, or a malformed file? Can affected users recover (do they still have the source data)? Is the export the headline of the launch or one feature among many? Who

decides, and how fast can it be fixed? Suppose the answers are: the 3% is from a test of 2,000 accounts; the source data stays intact, so users can export again after a fix; and the export is one of six features.

Principle. Do not ship a known data-corruption defect to users without their knowing; users' trust in their data is what a data product sells.

Options and tradeoffs. (A) Delay the whole launch until the fix: the safest and costs the launch event. (B) Launch with the export feature turned off behind a flag for everyone, and enable it when fixed: keeps most of the launch and loses one feature. (C) Launch with the export on and a warning: fast and exposes 3% of users to corrupt files, which they may not notice. (D) Launch on schedule to a small group first.

First action. I would choose B if the flag exists and the other five features are not affected: the harm is irreversible only if users act on corrupt files, and turning the feature off prevents that. I would tell the launch owner and support tonight, with the facts and the plan; ask engineering for a fix estimate and a test that covers the failing case; and prepare the message for users ("export will arrive next week; here's how to request it now"). If no flag exists and the export is central, I would recommend delaying the launch by the time to the fix, and say plainly what that costs.

Check. Re-test with the failing accounts; confirm the flag state in production; watch export-related contacts; hold a short review afterward on how the defect was missed, and add the case to the test suite.

Cost I accept. A launch without a feature the partners expected, a harder conversation with the launch owner, and possibly being seen as the person who made it smaller.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if the launch owner insists on shipping with the export on? **A.** "I'd show the test results and the likely number of affected users and ask them to decide with that information. If they still decided to ship a feature I believed would corrupt users' data, I'd raise it with the engineering and legal leads, in writing, and would not sign off on it. I would be explicit about the risk and the alternative I proposed."
- **Q.** What if the 3% figure were 0.1%? **A.** "The principle is the same, but the weighing changes: at 0.1% the cost of delay may outweigh the harm if affected users can be told and helped. I'd still disclose, prepare support and fix quickly, and I'd check whether 0.1% is a sample artifact before deciding."

IQ-C31-12 · Intermediate · behavioral · BE

Prompt. Tell me about a time you worked with a teammate who was not delivering.

Rubric.

- **Baseline:** "They were slow, so I did their work," or "I told my manager."
- **Strong:** Describes understanding the cause, a direct conversation and a result.

- **Standout:** Starts with curiosity about the cause, clarifies expectations in writing, offers specific help, brings in the manager with facts and the person's knowledge, protects the outcome and the relationship, and ends with a measurable result and a lesson.

Model answer. *Context (invented figures).* On a team of six I was the associate product manager for a checkout change, and a design colleague was consistently missing the dates we had agreed: in the first four weeks she delivered 2 of 5 committed pieces on time (40%). The launch was six weeks out.

Decision. I could take over her pieces, escalate to her manager, or find out why. I decided to start with a private conversation, because I didn't know the cause and assumed it might not be effort.

Action. I asked a neutral question: "I've noticed the last few dates slipped, and I want to make sure I'm giving you what you need. What's getting in the way?" She told me she was supporting two other projects with competing deadlines and that my requests arrived as changing priorities in chat. We agreed three things: I would send a single written brief for each piece with the acceptance criteria and a fixed date; we would hold a 15-minute check-in twice a week; and I would tell her manager, with her knowledge, that the team's design capacity was over-committed so that the priorities could be set at their level. I also moved two lower-value pieces out of the launch scope.

Result. In the next four weeks she delivered 9 of 10 pieces on time (90%), the launch shipped on its date with reduced scope, and her manager reduced her other commitments. She told me later that the written briefs were the most useful change.

Learning. The cause was a system problem (conflicting priorities and unclear requests) that looked like a person problem. I now check the cause before concluding, write requests down with criteria, and raise capacity problems with the manager as facts and not as complaints about a person.

Signals. Curiosity first; a direct, kind conversation; specific commitments; the manager informed with the person's knowledge; a measured result; a lesson.

Follow-ups.

- **Q.** What if it hadn't improved after those changes? **A.** "I'd have gone back to her with the facts: the dates, the effect on the launch and what we'd agreed, and asked what else would help. If it still did not improve, I'd talk to her manager with the same facts and what I'd already tried, and I'd protect the launch by reducing scope or finding other capacity. I'd keep the tone about the work and the outcome, not about her as a person, and I'd keep her informed of every step."
- **Q.** How did you avoid undermining her? **A.** "I raised it with her first and told her what I would say to her manager before I said it. I framed the capacity problem as a team issue, not her performance, and I credited her work to others when it went well. I didn't compare her with others or discuss her with the rest of the team."

12. Exercises

Ten exercises. Each has a model solution and an alternative. Every figure is invented, and all stories in the solutions are illustrative; use only what is true in your own work.

EX-C31-01 · Write your two-minute introduction

Problem. Using FW-C31-02, write a 230 to 280 word introduction for a candidate who studied computer science, spent two years as a software engineer on a team building a booking app, and wants to become a product manager. Invent plausible details and mark them (invented).

Context. The opening of every loop.

Data. None.

Constraints. Ten minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C31-02 and Worked example 1.

Solution. "I'm a software engineer on a six-person team that builds the booking flow for a hotel app used by about 300,000 travelers (invented). I got here in three steps. I studied computer science and, in my last year, built a trip-planning app for friends; the first thing I learned was that nobody used the feature I was proudest of, and everyone used one I had added in an afternoon. At my first job I built the payment screen, and when I noticed that 22% of people stopped at the address step, I asked our product manager if I could look into it; I added autofill and a clearer error message, and completion rose by 6 points. Then I started attending user interviews and asked to write the spec for a small feature, a saved-guests list, and I took it from the idea through launch, where it was used by 18% of bookers in the first month. That showed me that the part of the work I want to do is deciding what to build and why, with engineers as partners. I'm looking for a product role where I can use that technical background, and this team's work on reducing booking friction is the problem I've spent most time on. Happy to go deeper on any of these." (about 235 words)

Alternative solution. Open with the saved-guests launch as the headline proof point if the role is feature-focused.

Tradeoffs. A tight arc omits parts of the history; the omitted parts are available for questions.

EX-C31-02 · Replace the "we"

Problem. Rewrite this answer so that the interviewer can see what the candidate did: "We noticed that sign-ups were low, so we looked at the data, and we found a problem with the form, and we fixed it and sign-ups went up."

Context. Practice with a friend.

Data. Invent two numbers and mark them (invented).

Constraints. Five minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C31-03 and CS-C31-01.

Solution. "Sign-ups had dropped to 6.1% from 7.4% over two months (invented), and I took the question to the data team and asked for the funnel by step. I found that 29% of people who reached the form stopped at the phone-number field. My decision was between making it optional and making it clearer why we asked. I proposed making it optional, because an earlier survey showed that most people did not want to share it at that stage, and I wrote a one-page note for our product manager; I worked with an engineer for two days on the change and set up a comparison with a 10% holdout. Sign-ups recovered to 7.0%, and the holdout confirmed the change was the cause. What I learned was to look at the funnel by step before guessing at the cause." (Where the team did something, say so by role: "the engineer built it in two days.")

Alternative solution. Keep "we" only for the final result that the team shared, and attribute each action to a role.

Tradeoffs. Over-using "I" can sound like taking credit; naming roles keeps it honest.

EX-C31-03 · Build the notes for a story

Problem. From these raw facts, write the five-part notes (context, decision, action, result, learning) and two probes with answers: You were the analyst on a team that launched a referral program. The first month brought 4,000 referred sign-ups, which looked great, but you noticed that only 9% of them were still active after 30 days compared with 31% for other new users. Your manager wanted to report the 4,000. You reported both numbers, and the team changed the reward to depend on the friend's first purchase. After the change, 30-day activity of referred users rose to 24% (all invented).

Context. Preparing a data-driven-decision and integrity story.

Data. As above.

Constraints. Eight minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C31-03 and FW-C31-05.

Solution. *Context:* referral program; 4,000 referred sign-ups in the first month looked successful; 30-day activity was 9% against 31%. *Decision:* report the headline number only (the manager's preference) or report both and propose a change. *Action:* I computed the 30-day activity by source, checked that the difference was not due to a data error by comparing two sources, presented both numbers with a one-slide explanation, and proposed paying the reward on the friend's first purchase; worked with the engineer and the finance partner on the rule. *Result:* 30-day activity of referred users rose to 24%, and cost per active referred user fell by about a third. *Learning:* report the number that tells the truth, along with the headline, and bring a proposal. *Probe 1 (level 2):* "How did you know the 9% wasn't a data problem?" — "I compared activity counts from the product database and the analytics tool for a sample of 300 users, and they matched within 2%." *Probe 2 (level 3):* "What if your manager had insisted on only the 4,000?" — "I'd have asked him to look at the 9% with me and, if he still wanted only the headline, I'd have said I could not present it as success without the second number, and asked who else should decide."

Alternative solution. Add a third probe on the cost of the change to the referral rate.

Tradeoffs. Reporting a hard number may annoy a manager; it protects trust in your analysis.

EX-C31-04 · Judge the failure stories

Problem. Apply the failure-story test (FW-C31-06) to three candidate stories and say which is the best choice and why: (a) "My biggest failure was that I worked too many hours and burned out"; (b) "We launched late because the engineering team underestimated the work"; (c) "I recommended launching a new pricing page without a test, conversion fell 3%, I rolled it back after five days at a cost of about \$40,000 in revenue, and I now agree a rollback rule before any launch."

Context. Choosing a story.

Data. None.

Constraints. Five minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C31-06.

Solution. (a) Fails: no real cost to the product or users, no decision, and it is a disguised strength. (b) Fails: the cause is someone else's, there is no decision of yours, and it sounds like blame. (c) Passes: a real cost (\$40,000), your decision (recommended launching without a test), an honest reason (not given here and should be added: what made it seem right), a repair (rollback) and a behavior change (a rollback rule). Choose (c) and add the honest reason and an example of using the new habit.

Alternative solution. For (b), find your own part (did you challenge the estimate?) and tell that story instead.

Tradeoffs. A real failure is uncomfortable and far more credible.

EX-C31-05 · Prepare the probe ladder

Problem. For the story in EX-C31-03 prepare two probes at each of three levels with answers, including one thing that went wrong.

Context. Preparing for a long probe.

Data. The facts in EX-C31-03; invent small details and mark them (invented).

Constraints. Eight minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C31-05.

Solution. *Level 1:* "What exactly was your analysis?" — "I joined sign-up source to activity at day 30 for all users in the month and compared by source." "How long did it take?" — "Two days, plus a day to check the data." *Level 2:* "Why change the reward to the first purchase?" — "I looked at which reward timing correlated with activity in a small pilot; the first-purchase rule filtered out sign-ups made only for the reward." "What did finance say?" — "They wanted a cap on the reward; we agreed a cap of \$10." *Level 3:* "What would you do differently?" — "I would have looked at activity by source in the first week, not month one, so that we would have caught it earlier." "What do you still not know?" — "Whether the change

reduced total referrals, which fell 30%; I think that is acceptable, but I don't know what the long-term value of the lost referrals would have been." *What went wrong:* the first version of the comparison double-counted users who signed up twice; I found it when the totals did not match and fixed it before presenting.

Alternative solution. Add a probe on how the manager reacted.

Tradeoffs. Probe notes take time and prevent improvisation under pressure.

EX-C31-06 · Map your stories to a company's list

Problem. Using an invented bank of nine stories (conflict, failure, influence, ambiguity, customer focus, data decision, prioritization, leading, values), choose which three to lead with for a company that publishes a list emphasizing ownership, disagreeing and committing, diving deep into data and delivering results, and explain what you would not do.

Context. Preparing a loop.

Data. None.

Constraints. Six minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C31-01.

Solution. Lead with the stories that show those attributes through your own decisions: the conflict story where you disagreed and then committed (and protected the outcome), the data-driven decision with a measurable result, and a story where you took ownership of something outside your job description (the failure story, if you owned the repair). Support with the prioritization story for delivering results. What not to do: recite the principle names, invent a story for each principle, or use the same story twice in one loop. Use the attribute map for coverage and ordering only.

Alternative solution. If a theme has no story, develop a second angle on an existing one, truthfully, not a new invention.

Tradeoffs. Tailoring emphasis helps; forcing stories to fit sounds rehearsed.

EX-C31-07 · A situational answer

Problem. "Your engineering lead says a feature the CEO wants will take three times longer than planned. What would you do?" Answer using FW-C31-07.

Context. Situational prompt.

Data. None.

Constraints. Six minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C31-07 and C16.4.

Solution. *Clarify:* what is the estimate range and its assumptions, what part of it is risky, and what does the CEO need (a date, a capability, a demo)? *Principle:* make the tradeoff visible and keep trust with both sides. *Options:* cut scope to meet the date; move the date; add people early only if the work is separable (C15.4); test the riskiest part first with a spike.

First action: talk to the engineering lead to understand what drives the estimate and what the smallest version looks like; check the outside view against past projects; prepare two or three options with costs. *Then:* take the options to the CEO with my recommendation, framed as what we can have by when, and ask which matters most. *Check:* agree checkpoints to re-estimate after the spike. If I had faced this before, I would say so briefly and give the example.

Alternative solution. Start with a quick conversation with the CEO's chief of staff to learn what the CEO needs.

Tradeoffs. Presenting options takes longer than saying yes or no and avoids a hidden overrun.

EX-C31-08 · A values scenario

Problem. "Your team wants to add a feature that collects users' contact lists to improve friend suggestions. Users are not told clearly. Sign-ups are expected to rise 4%. What do you do?" Use FW-C31-08.

Context. Values prompt.

Data. None.

Constraints. Seven minutes.

Expected approach. FW-C31-08.

Solution. *Facts:* what exactly is collected, what is it used for, how long kept, who sees it; what the law and policy say about consent for contact data [V: GDPR Article 4(11) (clear affirmative action) and the ePrivacy Directive (opt-in for marketing email), as summarized in guidance]. *Stakeholders and harms:* users and the people in their contact lists, who never agreed; potential exposure of sensitive relationships; regulatory and trust risk. *Pressure and goal:* a 4% sign-up rise; the legitimate goal is better friend suggestions. *Options:* ship as planned; refuse; ask for contacts with a clear explanation and consent, with a choice to upload; compute matches on the device without sending contacts; test to measure the real lift against sign-up and complaint effects. *Principle:* clear consent and data minimization (C21.8). *Action:* raise with the product lead and the privacy owner with the options; propose the consented or on-device design and measure the lift; if the plan remained unclear to users, decline to implement and escalate in writing. *Cost:* a possible smaller lift, a longer timeline and a harder conversation.

Alternative solution. Propose a limited trial with consent to measure the benefit before deciding on broader collection.

Tradeoffs. Consent screens reduce uploads and protect trust and compliance.

EX-C31-09 · A favorite-product answer

Problem. Answer: "What is your favorite product, and what would you change?" using the formula (user, job, two decisions, one critique with improvement). Use any real product you know well; here, use a note-taking app as an invented example.

Context. A common opener.

Data. None.

Constraints. Six minutes.

Expected approach. C31.3 and C11.

Solution. "My favorite is a note-taking app I use daily. It's for people who capture quick thoughts on the phone and organize them later, and its job is to make capture instant. Two decisions I admire: it opens directly to a new note, with no folder choice, which respects that capture is urgent and sorting is not; and search is fast and forgiving of typos, which makes it safe to be messy. My critique: sharing a single note with someone who has no account requires them to sign up, which I think loses the moment of use; I'd test a view-only link without sign-up, measuring whether recipients later create accounts, with a guardrail on privacy complaints. I'm inferring the constraints here; I don't know whether there are reasons for the sign-up I can't see."

Alternative solution. Choose a product where you can describe a specific design tradeoff and its cost.

Tradeoffs. A critique shows taste and candor; an uninformed one shows neither.

EX-C31-10 · A timed mock behavioral round

Problem. With a partner acting as the interviewer, run a 45-minute round: a two-minute introduction, three story questions of your choice from the themes (with at least five minutes of probing each) and one values or situational question. Score yourself with the feedback checklist.

Context. Self-scored; record the session.

Data. Use your own true stories.

Constraints. Use the 45-minute budget in section 4.

Expected approach. The architecture in section 4 and the checklist in section 13.

Solution. A good performance: an introduction under two minutes with three proof points; each story with a stated decision and a number; clear "I" actions with credit for others; probes answered concretely with no invented detail; a failure with a changed habit; a values answer with a cost named; and questions at the end that are specific to the role. Common problems found in recordings: starting the context too long, using only "we," skipping the decision, and a vague learning. Fix one thing per session and rerecord.

Alternative solution. Ask the partner to probe only one story for fifteen minutes to practice depth.

Tradeoffs. Depth on fewer stories is more valuable than breadth with shallow answers.

13. Practice protocol

Timed drills (three a week for four weeks).

- *Week 1: inventory and introduction.* Build the inventory of 12 to 15 episodes (FW-C31-04), write and time the two-minute introduction (IQ-C31-01, EX-C31-01), and write the reasons for PM and for two target companies (IQ-C31-02).
- *Week 2: story anatomy and bank.* Write five-line notes for eight to ten stories, using EX-C31-02, EX-C31-03 and IQ-C31-03, IQ-C31-04, IQ-C31-07 as models. Time each at two to three minutes aloud.
- *Week 3: probes, failure and values.* Prepare probe ladders (EX-C31-05) for each story; write your failure story and test it (EX-C31-04, IQ-C31-08, IQ-C31-10); prepare a values story and run the frame (IQ-C31-05, IQ-C31-06, EX-C31-08); prepare a story about working with a teammate who is not delivering (IQ-C31-12).
- *Week 4: full rounds.* Run two mock rounds (EX-C31-10) with different partners, including situational questions (IQ-C31-11, EX-C31-07); record both and compare.

With a partner. Ask your partner to count your "we" and "I," to ask for numbers, and to probe three levels deep on every story. Ask them to interrupt with "What did you personally do?" at random.

Record yourself. Listen for length, filler, and the moment you start to ramble; mark where the decision and the result appear in the first 90 seconds.

Feedback checklist (yes, partly, no).

1. Was my introduction about two minutes, with scope, an arc and three proof points?
2. Were my reasons for PM and for this company specific and honest?
3. Did each story have a context, a decision, an action, a result with a number and a learning?
4. Did I say what I did, with credit to others?
5. Did I answer probes concretely without inventing detail?
6. Was my failure real, owned and followed by a changed habit?
7. Did my values or situational answer name the harm, the goal behind the pressure, the options and the cost?
8. Did I answer the question asked, and stay within time?
9. Did I use stories that are true, and avoid confidential information?
10. Did I finish with questions that show I understand the role?

Answer journal. For each drill record the date, the prompt, the story used, the length, the number and decision you included, the probe you struggled with, your score out of ten and the one fix for next time.

14. Implementation playbook

Use the next three weeks to build your bank from real work. Each deliverable is a preparation asset and a record of your own judgment.

Days 1 to 3. Write the inventory of 12 to 15 episodes from your last two years, including projects outside your job. For each, one line on what you decided. Mark the five where your decision mattered most.

Week 1. Write five-line notes (context, decision, action, result, learning) for eight stories, with verified numbers and what you can and cannot share. Cover the nine themes (FW-C31-04). Ask a colleague who saw the events to check your account for accuracy and credit.

Week 1. Write and time your introduction and your reasons for PM and for two target companies. Replace any generic phrase with a fact.

Week 2. Prepare two probes at each level for every story, with answers, and one thing that went wrong in each. Find the story where you were partly wrong and prepare to tell it.

Week 2. Draft your failure story and test it (FW-C31-06); draft a values story and apply the frame (FW-C31-08). If you do not have a values story, find an episode where you raised a concern and write it honestly, including what it cost.

Week 3. Run two recorded mock rounds with different partners and fix the one thing that most often shows up: all "we," no decision, a missing number or running over time.

Deliverables that become your assets: the inventory and the notes (your story bank), the probe ladders, the failure and values stories, and two recordings. Keep every number real and every credit accurate; the bank is only worth what its facts are worth under questioning.

15. Key takeaways and further reading

Key takeaways

1. The behavioral round tests what you actually did, how you decided and what you learned, through the signals your stories give; a story with no decision, no personal action and no evidence gives none.
2. Prepare a two-minute introduction with scope, an arc with reasons and three proof points, and honest, evidence-based reasons for product management and for each company, not generic motives.
3. Tell stories in five parts (context, decision, action, result with a number, learning) in two to three minutes, separate your actions from the team's with "I" and "we", and keep every detail true.
4. Build a bank of eight to ten real stories mapped to the themes (conflict, failure, influence, ambiguity, customer focus, a data decision, prioritization, leading, values), prepare probes three levels deep for each, and use published company attributes only to check coverage and ordering.

5. Handle failure, weakness, hypotheticals and values scenarios with judgment: a real cost and a changed habit, a structured answer with a chosen action, and a stated cost for doing the right thing, never a speech or a guess at what the interviewer wants.

Further reading

- Amazon's published Leadership Principles on its careers site, read directly and with the date in mind [V: Amazon Leadership Principles].
- Google's, Meta's, Microsoft's, Netflix's and Stripe's published descriptions of their hiring attributes, values or culture, where available, for the attribute map [V: company pages named, checked as sources in October 2026].
- Daniel Kahneman, *Thinking, Fast and Slow* (2011), on the limits of confidence in memory and judgment, which helps in reconstructing your stories honestly [V: Kahneman, Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2011, ISBN 978-0374275631].
- Chip Heath and Dan Heath, *Made to Stick* (2007), on telling concrete, memorable stories [V: Random House, 2 January 2007, ISBN 9781400064281].
- Thomas Moore, "The fight to save Tylenol," *Fortune*, 29 November 1982 (fortune.com/article/the-fight-to-save-tylenol-fortune-1982/); the University of New Mexico Daniels Fund Ethics Initiative case study of the 1982 Tylenol recall; and the FDA compliance policy guide CPG 450.500 on tamper-resistant packaging. The sources for CS-C31-02.
- Amy Edmondson, *The Fearless Organization* (2018), on candor and psychological safety, relevant to feedback stories [V: Wiley, 20 November 2018 (some catalogs date it 2019), ISBN 9781119477242].